

Chapter 83-5

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Liang Shi's voice at that moment was so pleasant that Xu Qingzhu simply followed her decision without even thinking about how going to see the ocean late at night was a very foolish idea.

And Liang Shi, who was no longer that drunk after drinking a cup of honey water, pulled Xu Qingzhu out of the house after proposing to see the ocean.

Xu Qingzhu drove toward the seaside on the outskirts of the city. Liang Shi sat in the car bobbing her head along to the music.

Haizhou City was a coastal city with an entire coastline. It became a popular tourist destination at the turn of spring and summer, so seeing the ocean late at night wasn't difficult to achieve.

It was just a bit... foolish.

When the car stopped by the roadside, and the moment they got out they could hear the sound of waves, and the air was filled with the salty, briny smell of the sea, and the wind was so cold that if you weren't careful it would burrow into your clothes, invade your body, and make you shiver—Xu Qingzhu felt that she might be an idiot, a lunatic.

A lunatic who came along to be crazy with Liang Shi.

But Liang Shi didn't feel cold at all. She even took off the black wool coat she was wearing, leaving only a light blue shirt. Her long hair danced wildly in the wind. She ran onto the beach, took off her shoes, and stood at the water's edge, facing the ocean.

The beach that was bustling during the day was now completely empty. The searchlights in the distance shone brightly, and Liang Shi's shadow fell on the beach.

Watching her, Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but feel she looked so lonely.

She stood there as if she didn't belong in this world.

After pausing for a few seconds, Xu Qingzhu cupped her hands around her mouth and shouted loudly: "Liang Shi!"

Liang Shi turned around. The wind had blown her hair over her eyes. She used one hand to brush it aside, and when she looked at Xu Qingzhu, she revealed a faint smile. "Hm?"

Her thin voice was swallowed by the waves. Wave after wave rolled in with the wind, bringing along a pile of marine creatures, wetting Liang Shi's feet. When the tide was strong, the seawater even covered her ankles.

Xu Qingzhu didn't hear her reply, but she still walked all the way to her side and stood shoulder to shoulder with her.

Xu Qingzhu asked her: "Why did you suddenly want to see the ocean?"

Liang Shi walked along the beach holding her coat. She asked Xu Qingzhu: "What's your dream?"

Xu Qingzhu was taken aback. She glanced sideways at her. "Are you still drunk right now?"

Liang Shi stopped in her tracks. She smiled and shook her head, very different from her usual self. "I don't know."

Xu Qingzhu understood—half drunk.

Not as crazy as before.

"Do you still remember what happened just now?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi breathed out lightly. "What happened?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Forget it, she gave up.

She would just wait for Liang Shi to review it herself tomorrow after completely sobering up.

Xu Qingzhu redirected the topic back to her earlier question. "Then what's your dream?"

Liang Shi laughed lightly. "You're cheating. I asked you first."

Xu Qingzhu: "Then you answer first."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi paused for a moment. "So childish."

"You're the childish one." Xu Qingzhu said.

After a while, Liang Shi kicked at some sand. She said: "My dream is to have lots and lots of love. I want everyone to like me."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly stopped. She looked at Liang Shi. "Liang Shi, were you kidnapped when you were little?"

Liang Shi also stopped following her footsteps, turned around and looked at her from not too far away, shaking her head. "I don't know."

"What do you mean?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. "I don't have any memories from before I was eight years old."

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "Be more specific."

"I don't remember what happened before I was eight." Liang Shi said. "I remember Madam Qi, I remember Qi Jiao, but those are all things I recalled in dreams. I don't have any memories from before I was eight. Including my original parents—I don't remember them either. They passed away before I turned eight. I grew up with my grandparents."

Liang Shi suddenly squatted down, and Xu Qingzhu squatted down with her.

This was the first time Xu Qingzhu heard her talk about things from "the other side."

Actually, she had always felt that when Liang Shi said she wasn't the original Liang Shi, it didn't feel real.

Now Xu Qingzhu had already forgotten what the previous Liang Shi was like. She only remembered "very bad," very annoying.

But the current Liang Shi was completely different. If you actually calculated it, it hadn't been that long, but she had already completely adapted to the current Liang Shi.

As if Liang Shi was supposed to be like this.

The one before was just someone else.

Not the jiejie who was kidnapped with her when they were little, nor the person she wanted to marry.

Xu Qingzhu had been busy with her own matters, and since she felt that Liang Shi didn't really want to bring up the past, she had deliberately suppressed her own curiosity.

So she had never asked, and thus had no way of knowing.

A drunk Liang Shi seemed to have a strong desire to share. She took the initiative to mention the past, to mention the family she grew up with.

And this wasn't the first time Xu Qingzhu heard her say: "I want to have lots of love."

Xu Qingzhu had watched that movie and had heard others say that line.

But the same tone, the same falling intonation at the end—only Liang Shi was like this.

When that sentence came from her mouth, it gave Xu Qingzhu an immense sense of familiarity. When anyone else said it, there was none.

Xu Qingzhu had even discussed this with her therapist.

The therapist's advice was to observe slowly. If there were more small details to support it, then that would indicate the two were the same person.

Because Xu Qingzhu's memory of being kidnapped was very vivid, especially regarding the person who saved her, that memory was particularly clear and unlikely to be wrong.

Xu Qingzhu faced her and asked: "What kind of people were your grandparents?"

Liang Shi suddenly smiled, her smile carrying nostalgia and longing. "They were very simple people. They didn't have much money, but every cent they earned, they wanted to spend on me."

"When I was in middle school, I went to the county town to participate in a running competition. Grandma bought me a pair of shoes for five hundred yuan¹." Liang Shi said. "Maybe five hundred is nothing to you all, and to me now, five hundred is nothing either. But back then, five hundred was money my grandma had to save for two months to accumulate."

"And Grandpa—he was very fierce, but he would ride his bicycle to take me to faraway places. He would take me to catch dragonflies and fireflies. He would hold up a world map and tell me that the world is big, and I shouldn't just stay here."

Liang Shi's eyes glistened with tears. She looked at Xu Qingzhu. "So after they passed away, I went to the big city. I became an actress, wanting to make many people like me, because they once told me that I would definitely become a shining person."

Xu Qingzhu raised her hand, her palm resting on Liang Shi's cheek.

Liang Shi's face moved slightly, nuzzling against her palm. "The thing Grandpa and Grandma wanted to do most was to see the ocean, but they never got to see it. So I came to fulfill their dream for them."

Footnotes:

¹ **Five hundred yuan (五百):** At the time referenced (likely 10-15 years ago in a rural area), 500 yuan would be a significant amount of money for a low-income family. For context, this would be roughly equivalent to 70-80 USD, but the purchasing power and relative value would be much higher in rural China. The fact that it took the grandmother two months to save this amount indicates the family's economic circumstances.